

SECURITY TRAINING

Phishing Awareness

Learn to Identify, Analyse and Defend Against Phishing Attacks

WHAT IS PHISHING?

Definition

Phishing is a type of cyber attack where criminals disguise themselves as trustworthy sources — such as banks, colleagues or well-known companies — to trick individuals into revealing sensitive information.

Common goals of phishing include:

- Stealing login credentials (usernames & passwords)
- Gaining access to financial or personal data
- Installing malware or ransomware on devices
- Compromising corporate systems and networks

91%

of cyberattacks begin with a phishing email

3.4B

phishing emails are sent every single day

EXAMPLE: A PHISHING EMAIL

✉ New Message

From: mastercardsIT@gmail.com
To: employee@email.com
Subject: URGENT! Password Reset Required—

Hello (insert name),

Your email account has been compromised. Immediate action is required to reset your password!

Click here to reset your password in the next hour or your account will be locked:

[\[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Phishing\]](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Phishing)

Regards,
Mastercard IT

⚠ Red Flags Identified

- Sender uses gmail.com — not a corporate domain
- Typo in address: 'mastercardsIT' vs 'mastercardIT'
- URGENT subject line designed to cause panic
- Greeting uses placeholder: (insert name)
- Poor grammar and exaggerated threat
- Bare link not masked in descriptive text
- No support or contact information provided

LEARN TO SPOT PHISHING EMAILS

Phishing emails rely on well-known psychological tactics to manipulate you into acting without thinking.

Urgency & Fear

Messages that warn of immediate consequences ("Your account will be locked!") to pressure fast action without reflection.

Impersonation

Attackers pose as trusted organisations — banks, IT departments or colleagues — to seem legitimate.

Suspicious Links

Links that appear legitimate but redirect to malicious sites. Always hover before clicking to check the real URL.

Spoofed Addresses

Email addresses that look genuine but contain small misspellings (e.g. mastercardsIT@gmail.com instead of a proper domain).

Generic Greetings

"Dear Customer" or "Hello User" instead of your name signals a bulk phishing campaign rather than a personal message.

Unexpected Attachments

Unsolicited attachments — even from known contacts — may contain malware. Verify before opening.

How Do We Stop Getting Phished?

01

Verify the sender — Always check the full email address carefully, not just the display name.

02

Think before you click — Hover over links to preview the actual URL. When in doubt, navigate directly to the site.

03

Never share credentials — Legitimate organisations will never ask for your password via email.

04

Report suspicious emails — Use the phishing report button in your email client or contact IT immediately.

05

Enable Multi-Factor Authentication — Even if credentials are stolen, MFA provides a critical second layer of protection.



EXAMPLE: AN IMPROVED (CONVINCING) PHISHING EMAIL

This is one example of an improved phishing email — there are many different ways this could have been constructed.

✉ New Message

From: Mastercard Staff Rewards <rewards@MastercardStaffRewards.com>
To: employee@email.com
Subject: Your Black Friday Employee Reward Card

Hello <name>,

In recognition of your hard work, we wish to reward you with a gift card for the upcoming Black Friday sales. Please find attached your Employee Reward Card.

To view your balance and activate your card, [visit here](#).

For any questions, please contact Staff Rewards support: rewards-support@mastercard.com

From, Staff Reward Services

CONFIDENTIAL: This email and any files transmitted with it are intended solely for the named recipient. If received in error, contact the system manager.

✓ Why It's Convincing

- **Legitimate domain:** Email comes from @MastercardStaffReward.com
- **Correct spelling:** 'Mastercard Staff Rewards' — no typos in sender name
- **Personalised greeting:** Uses recipient's name to build trust and familiarity
- **Contextual pretext:** Tied to Black Friday — a real, timely event employees expect
- **Masked link:** "visit here" hides the actual malicious URL behind plain text
- **Buffer text added:** Support contact details increase perceived legitimacy
- **Confidentiality notice:** Standard disclaimer makes the email look official and legal

Why Is It a Good Phishing Email?

The improved phishing email works because it exploits human psychology and overcomes the common checks people use to detect fraud:

- 01 Trust through familiarity:** By referencing Black Friday — a real event employees look forward to — the email creates a believable context. People are far less suspicious when an email aligns with something they were already expecting.
- 02 Authority and legitimacy:** Using a professional sender name, a plausible domain, and a formal confidentiality notice mimics genuine corporate communications. This reduces the instinct to question the email's origin.
- 03 Emotional reward hook:** A promise of a reward card appeals to positive emotions, lowering a recipient's critical guard. Unlike fear-based attacks, this approach feels positive and non-threatening.
- 04 Technical concealment:** By masking the phishing link as 'visit here', the attacker hides the malicious URL from a quick visual check — defeating the most commonly taught defensive behaviour.

Key Takeaway

**Phishing
succeeds when
it feels normal.**

The best defence is slowing down and questioning anything that asks you to click a link or provide information — even if it seems legitimate.